

Romans

The Just Man

Ch. 3-4

The Predicament of Mankind

“The wrath of God is revealed...” “...For all have sinned...”

Romans 1 : The “Pagan Man”

- ***For Suppressing God’s Truth*** (v.18)
- ***For Ignoring God’s Revelation*** (v.19-20)
- ***For Perverting God’s Glory*** (v.21-23)

Romans 2 : The “Moral Man”

- ***According to Truth*** (v. 2)
- ***According to Accumulated Guilt*** (v. 5)
- ***According to Works*** (v. 6)
- ***Without Respect of Persons*** (v. 11)
- ***According to Obedience*** (v. 13)
- ***According to Secrets of the Heart*** (v. 16)
- ***According to Reality*** (v. 17-29)

Romans 3 : The “Religious Man”

- ***Our Conscience is an Indicator of a Need for Righteousness and a basis for Religion*** (v. 2:14-15)
- ***God recognizes Obedience from the Heart*** (v. 2:29)

The Pagan Man - They Became Fools...

Man’s refusal to acknowledge and glorify God leads to a downward path:

- First, worthless thinking;
- Next, moral insensitivity; and
- Then, religious stupidity as seen in idol-worship!

The witness to God in nature is so clear and so constant that ignoring it is indefensible.

- **The pagan man’s condemnation is based not on their rejecting Christ of whom they have not heard,**
- **But sinning against the Light that they do have.** *2 Corinthians 8:12*

NOTE: God’s prior judgments of mankind (i.e. condemnations) reveal that He judged them apart from the Law and according to the eternal principles of His Revealed Truth (e.g. Sodom and Gomorrah, Noah’s Flood).

The Moral Man – Seven Principles of God’s Righteous Judgment

**** The First Law of Holes... stop digging! ****

Let us not confuse Romans 2 with Revelation 20... at Judgment Day, there will be no reasoning nor preaching; only condemnation; based upon the Principles of God’s Judgment.

The Agent of divine judgment is Jesus Christ. John 5:22, 27; Acts 17:31

Judgment

- The Same Measuring Stick (we all know and use the same stick):
 - *Romans 2:1-2*
 - *Matthew 7:1-2 (passing judgment should give us pause...)*
- ***Does not imply “do not pass judgment – i.e. discernment”***
 - *1 Corinthians 2:14-16 – the spiritual man makes judgment about all things*
- Different judgments
 - Examples of prior Judgments (with condemnation) by God: *Ezekiel 16:48-50* (Sodom and Gomorrah – pride **and** sexual perversion; see also *Luke 17:28-30*)
 - At the end: *Revelation 20:13-15 (“...treasuring up for yourself wrath...” Romans 2:5)*
 - ***Even the Christian: 1 Cor. 3:11-15 (but not condemned...! John 5:24; Romans 8:1)***

The Grace of God Revealed

How *the* perfectly just LORD has forgiven sin...!

*“Blessed is he whose transgression is **forgiven**,
whose sin is **covered**,
Blessed is the man to whom
the **LORD** does **not impute iniquity**,
And in whose spirit there is **no deceit**.”*

• ***Psalm 32:1-2; Romans 4:7-8***

*“...that **He might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus**.”* Romans 3:26

FIRST - Read Romans 3:21-26

THE QUESTION:

- How can a perfectly **just** God forgive sins?
- How can **sinful** man find favor with a **righteous** God?

THE ANALOGY:

- God (the Son) presides as the Judge of mankind (pagan, moral, and spiritual men). John 5:22
- The Son steps down from the Judgment seat and assumes the seat of the plaintiff (mankind). Isaiah 53:11
- The Son himself assumes the just penalty of sin for all of sinful mankind.
- The Father is satisfied with the just payment for sin.
- The Father demonstrates mercy by extending the righteousness of one man to cover many. 2 Cor. 5:21

God demonstrates His perfect justice at the same time that he demonstrates His perfect mercy... in the act of delivering justice, he also justifies.

Eph. 2:8 “For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, lest anyone should boast.

Hallelujah! What a Savior!

A quick review...

Truth, The Nature of Mankind, and Worldviews

- **Truth** is objective, knowable, and personified in Jesus of Nazareth. (John 14:6-11; John 18:37; Acts 2:22)
- The **Natural Man** recognizes God's creativity and intelligence in the created order; *but suppresses the truth in unrighteousness*. (Romans 1)
- The **Moral Man** recognizes how things ought to be; *but falls short of God's goodness revealed via his own conscience and rationality*. (Romans 2)
- The **Religious Man** recognizes that God exists, and that God has expectations; *but succumbs to selfish pride, artificial authority, arrogance, and hypocrisy*. (Romans 3)
- The **Just Man** relies upon God's promise, lives by faith; *and receives the blessing of imputed righteousness*. (Romans 4)

World-View – Common to all men everywhere always.

1. Origins (Where do we come?)
2. Meaning (Why are we here?)
3. Morality (How should we live?)
4. Destiny (Where are we going?)

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The Spiritual Man – A New Creation

1 Cor. 2:6-16; 2 Cor. 5:16-21; Galatians 5; Romans 8

Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have passed away; behold, all things have become new. (2 Cor. 5:17)

***What is meant by ‘Knowing God’?
(Jer. 31:31-34; Heb. 8:6-12)***

- ***An Internal, Heart-Level Knowledge (Jer. 31:33)***
- ***A Personal Relationship mediated through Jesus Christ (John 14:6)***
- ***Obedience as a Sign of Knowledge; a Practical Test (1 John 2:3-6)***
- ***Love as the Outflow of Knowing God; a Practical Test (1 John 4:7-8)***
- ***The Witness of the Holy Spirit (Romans 8:12-17)***
- ***The Fruit of the Spirit; a Practical Test (Galatians 5:22-25)***
- ***The Mind of Christ; a World-View Test (1 Corinthians 2:16)***

You can know that you know the Lord when your heart has been changed by Him, when you have come to Him through faith in Jesus Christ, when your life exhibits loving obedience to His commands, and when the Holy Spirit is actively at work within you. This inward transformation, evidenced in loving God and others, marks the reality of the relationship promised in Jeremiah’s prophecy of the new covenant.

When Paul lists the “fruit of the Spirit” (Gal. 5:22–23)—love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control—he’s describing the character and conduct that flow out of a life yielded to God’s Spirit. Although the explicit phrase “Holy Spirit” appears less frequently in the Old Testament, several psalms not only point to “living the good life” (i.e., walking in covenant faithfulness and blessing) but also reference or imply the work of God’s Spirit in shaping that life.

In **Jeremiah 31:31–34**, God promises a “new covenant” in which **His law will be written on people’s hearts**, and as a result, **“they shall all know me.”** This new covenant relationship implies an intimate, personal knowledge of God rather than a merely external or secondhand acquaintance. To understand how one can know they truly “know the LORD,” it’s helpful to consider several biblical principles that clarify the nature and evidence of this relationship.

1. An Internal, Heart-Level Knowledge:

Under the new covenant, God’s law is not just a set of external rules; it is internalized. This indicates that truly knowing the LORD involves a changed heart—a shift from merely following religious observances to experiencing a genuine inward transformation (**Jeremiah 31:33**). Thus, one sign of knowing the Lord is the deep, inner desire to love, honor, and please Him, not because of external pressure, but because one’s heart has been made new.

2. A Personal Relationship Through Christ:

The New Testament reveals that Jesus Christ mediates this new covenant. Through faith in Christ’s death and resurrection, believers enter into a restored relationship with God (Hebrews 8:6–12, John 14:6). Knowing the Lord, then, is inseparable from knowing Christ. If you have placed your trust in Jesus, believing His sacrifice for your sins, and have become His disciple, this faith relationship is a foundational indicator that you know God.

3. Obedience as a Sign of Knowledge:

First John gives practical tests for knowing God:

1 John 2:3–6: *Now by this we know that we know Him, if we keep His commandments. He who says, "I know Him," and does not keep His commandments, is a liar, and the truth is not in him. But whoever keeps His word, truly the love of God is perfected in him. By this we know that we are in Him. He who says he abides in Him ought himself also to walk just as He walked.*

4. Love as the Outflow of Knowing God:

Another test of knowing the Lord is found in love.

1 John 4:7–12: *Beloved, let us love one another, for love is of God; and everyone who loves is born of God and knows God. He who does not love does not know God, for God is love. In this the love of God was manifested toward us, that God has sent His only begotten Son into the world, that we might live through Him. In this is love, not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son to be the propitiation for our sins. Beloved, if God so loved us, we also ought to love one another. No one has seen God at any time. If we love one another, God abides in us, and His love has been perfected in us.*

5. The Witness of the Holy Spirit:

Under the new covenant, God’s Spirit dwells within believers:

Romans 8:12-17: *Therefore, brethren, we are debtors—not to the flesh, to live according to the flesh. For if you live according to the flesh you will die; but if by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body, you will live. For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, these are sons of God. For you did not receive the spirit of bondage again to fear, but you received the Spirit of adoption by whom we cry out, "Abba, Father." The Spirit Himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, and if children, then heirs—heirs of God and joint heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him, that we may also be glorified together.*

Summary:

You can know that you know the Lord when your heart has been changed by Him, when you have come to Him through faith in Jesus Christ, when your life exhibits loving obedience to His commands, and when the Holy Spirit is actively at work within you. This inward transformation, evidenced in loving God and others, marks the reality of the relationship promised in Jeremiah’s prophecy of the new covenant.

Encouraging Self-Reflection in Evangelism

Leveraging the Nature of Man - Objectives

- 1. Establish the Reality of God's Existence and Moral Law.**
- 2. Convict the Conscience Through God's Law.**
- 3. Illustrate the Consequence of Sin (God's Justice).**
- 4. Present the Gospel of Grace (Jesus both Just and Justifier).**
- 5. Call for Repentance, Faith, and a Covenant Relationship via Baptism.**

Topical Objectives:

1. Establish the Reality of God's Existence and Moral Law:

The approach aims to move beyond abstract spiritual discussions and highlight that God has revealed a moral standard (the Ten Commandments) that everyone has broken.

2. Convict the Conscience Through God's Law:

By using the Ten Commandments, the method seeks to stir a sense of guilt over personal sin, demonstrating that no one is truly "good" by God's perfect moral standard.

3. Illustrate the Consequence of Sin (God's Justice):

The goal is to show that sin is not trivial. It brings serious consequence—eternal separation from God—because God is just and must punish wrongdoing.

4. Present the Gospel of Grace:

After conviction comes the good news: Jesus Christ fulfilled the Law, paid the penalty for sin through His death and resurrection, and offers forgiveness and eternal life as a free gift.

5. Call for Repentance, Faith, and a Covenant Relationship via Baptism

The final objective is to encourage the person to repent (turn from sin) and trust in Jesus Christ alone for salvation, leading to a reconciled relationship with God.

Evangelism

The “Natural Man” – How do you know?

*For **since the creation of the world His invisible attributes are clearly seen**, being understood by the things that are made, even His eternal power and Godhead, so that **they are without excuse**, because, although they knew God, they did not glorify Him as God, nor were thankful, but became futile in their thoughts, and their foolish hearts were darkened. (Romans 1)*

Does God Exist?

Argument from Creation (Law of Causality):

1. The universe had a beginning.
2. Anything that has a beginning must have been caused by something else.
3. Therefore, the universe was caused by something else, and this cause was God.

Argument from Intelligent Design (Laws of Information and Entropy):

1. All designs imply a Designer.
2. There is great design in the universe.
3. Therefore, there must be a Great Designer of the universe.

Naturalism – the belief that nature is all that there is.

Creation proves that there is a Creator.

The Empiricist looks to nature for truth; what he observes. God reveals Himself to men of this type via his creation.

Uniformity of Nature (e.g. the “Laws of Nature” being uniform across time & space) speak to the character of God. Such uniformity cannot be explained if the natural world were based upon mere randomness.

e.g. “Why is the universe discoverable? Understandable? Bound by natural laws? Comprising information?”

The universe reflects the unchanging character of God. We are made in his image and thus able to understand his creation.

Evangelism

The “Moral Man” – Are you a good person?

*“...(for not the hearers of the law are just in the sight of God, but the doers of the law will be justified; for when Gentiles, who do not have the law, by nature do the things in the law, these, although, not having the law, are a law to themselves, who show the work of the law **written in their hearts, their conscience also bearing witness, and between themselves their thoughts accusing or else excusing them**)...” (Romans 2)*

Would you consider yourself to be a good person?

Argument from Moral Law:

1. All men are conscious of an objective moral law. (Indicated by conscience.)
2. Moral Laws imply a moral Lawgiver.
3. Therefore, there must be a universal moral Lawgiver.

The Moral Man looks inward for truth; what he reasons (i.e. Logic, Conscience).

The “Will of God” observable in nature. (The Law of Moses may be considered a revealed specification of this natural law.)

Moral laws don’t describe what is; they prescribe what ought to be. They are not simply a description of the way men behave, and are not known by observing what men do. If they were, our idea of morality would surely be different. Instead, they tell us what men ought to do, whether they are doing it or not. Thus, any moral “ought” comes from beyond the natural universe. You can’t explain it by anything that happens in the universe. It transcends the natural order and requires a transcendent cause. (“When Skeptics Ask”, Norman L. Geisler)

God has reveals Himself to this type of man within the concepts of right and wrong (via the conscience).

Morals reflect the character of God. We are made in His image and thus able to reason using logic of which he is the source.

Practical Example

Made evident using questions from the Law.

Questions:

Would you consider yourself to be a good person?

Do you think that you have kept the Ten Commandments?

Have you ever lied?

Have you ever stolen something?

Have you committed adultery? Perhaps even in your thoughts?

Have you disobeyed and dishonored your parents?

If God were to judge you by the Ten Commandments, do you think you would be innocent or guilty?

Are you aware of the Law of Sin and Death? Do you think that applies to you too?

Do you think that you would escape the consequences of this law?

Follow-on Questions:

Does that concern you?

Did you know that Jesus overcame the Law of Sin and Death for all humanity?

Do you want to know more about how to become “right” with God?

Evangelism

The “Religious Man” – What do you believe?

*“Now we know that whatever the law says, it says to those who are under the law, that every mouth may be stopped, and all the world may become guilty before God. Therefore, by the deeds of the law no flesh will be justified in His sight, **for the law is the knowledge of sin.**” (Romans 3)*

What about your belief-system? Aren’t you seeking to justify yourself with God? (Matthew 5:17-20; Matthew 22:32-46)

1. Reduces to a form of self-righteousness.
2. God uses the Law to strip the person of what he’s trusting in – his self-righteousness. The wrath of God is thus revealed.
3. In trying to justify himself through “good works”, he is attempting to bribe the Judge of the Universe. *Aren’t you trying to justify yourself? Why?*

Why was Jesus here? What does He want of us?

“Jesus said to him, ‘I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.’” John 14:6

The Religious Man looks to religion for truth; what he believes. He recognizes the Sin Nature of Man and seeks to “work” his way to a “right” relationship with his god.

God reveals Himself to men of this type via his special revelation of sin under the law (e.g. via the prototypical Jew) and redemption by grace within Christ.

Man says...

Humanism – man is the measure of all things.

Atheism – god doesn’t exist.

Pantheism – creation itself is the measure of all things.

God says...

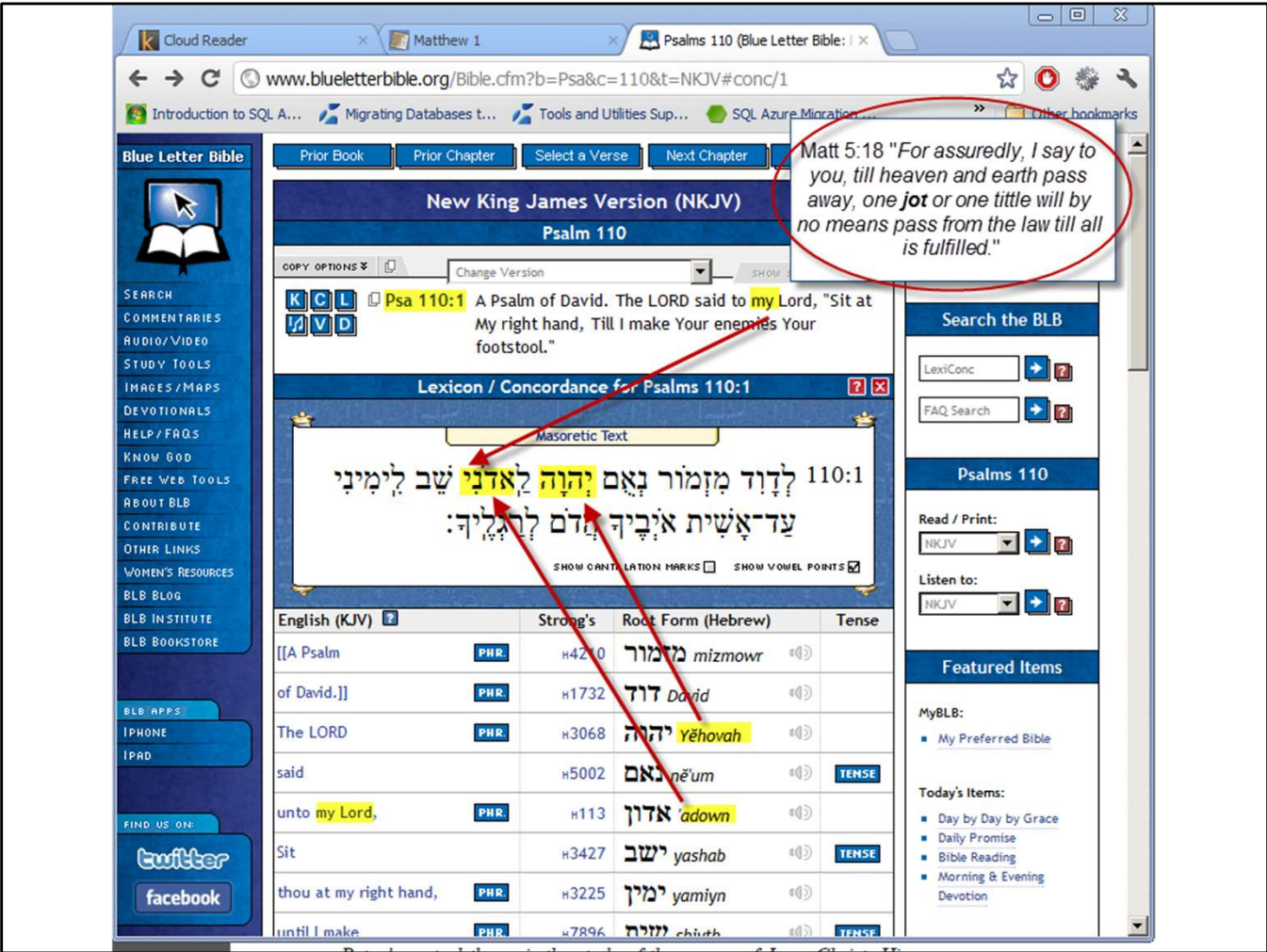
Hebrews 1:1 “God, who at various times and in various ways spoke in time past to the fathers by the prophets, has in these last days spoken to us by His Son, whom He has appointed heir of all things, through whom also He made the worlds; who being the brightness of His glory and the express image of His person, and upholding all things by the word of His power, when He had by Himself purged our sins, sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high,...”

Five key questions to focus conversation with non-believers:

1. What do you mean by _____?
2. How do you know?
3. What difference does that make?
4. What if you are wrong?
5. What would you accept as evidence?

What about semi-Christians?

1. 2 Corinthians 13:5 - “examine yourself, test your faith”
2. Do you read your Bible often?



An example of how Jesus responded to an errant religious system of beliefs...

We should be reminded of Jesus’ words as quoted in **Matthew 5:18**... “...one jot or one tittle will by no means pass from the law till all is fulfilled.”

The jot is the Hebrew character illustrated here that looks similar to an apostrophe. It modifies the preceding word to form a ‘possessive’ grammar (e.g. Lord becomes “my Lord”).

Jesus used this passage (Psalm 110:1) to confuse the Pharisees who could not reconcile the concept of “Son of God” versus “Son of David” (whose throne they regard as that upon which the Messiah must be coming to fulfill).

“The Son of David” versus “The Son of GOD” Matthew 22:34-46 (41-46) (also: Mark 12; Luke 20; Acts 2)

The Jewish religious leaders were incorrectly focused on the Davidic Kingdom aspect of prophetic scripture. They expected (perhaps demanded) God to provide a Messiah that would rule the Earth from Jerusalem. Jesus uses a Messianic prophecy written by David himself to confound their reasoning. What did David mean when he prophesied concerning the Christ?

The small mark that appears at the end of the upper red arrow is a “jot”. It looks somewhat like an apostrophe. This jot is appended to the word “Lord” and creates a “possessive” context around that word (i.e. “my Lord”). Hence, the rendering “Jehovah said to my Adonai...” (in effect, the Christ would sit at the throne of God Himself, not in Jerusalem; certainly not an earthly throne.)

Encouraging Self-Reflection

What do you believe about [...]?

How do you know?

What do you mean by [...]?

What difference does that make?

What if you are wrong?

What would you accept as evidence?

Encouraging Self-Reflection

Questions for the “Natural Man” of Romans 1

Focus: Creation as revelation of God’s existence and attributes.

- **“When you look at the vastness of the night sky, the order of the seasons, or the complexity of life, do you ever wonder if there is a purposeful Intelligence behind it all?”**
- **“You appreciate the beauty and intricacy of nature, but have you considered why beauty and order exist at all, and what their ultimate source might be?”**
- **“Our world follows laws - of physics, chemistry, biology - that never seem to change. Wouldn’t a timeless, intelligent Lawgiver best explain the consistent reliability of these laws?”**
- **“If the universe had a beginning, what or who do you think caused it to come into being, and how might that cause be greater than the universe itself?”**

Herein are examples of questions tailored to each type of individual described in Romans 1 through 4; Natural, Moral, Religious, and Just; intended to prompt them to consider the evidence for God’s existence and His self-revelation as described in Romans. These questions aim not to coerce but to encourage honest reflection, drawing on what each category of person already perceives or values.

Each set of questions is designed to resonate with the assumptions and experiences of these four “types” of people. The idea is to lead them from their current vantage point; whether it’s an appreciation of nature, a commitment to morality, a religious intuition, or a faithful trust in God’s promises; toward recognizing that the God of the Bible has made Himself known in creation, conscience, revelation, and ultimately in Jesus Christ.

Encouraging Self-Reflection

Questions for the “Moral Man” of Romans 2

Focus: Universal moral standards as inner testimony to God’s character.

- **“You have a sense of right and wrong; where do you think that sense originates, and why do you feel accountable to it?”**
- **“If moral standards were merely social constructs, why do you still feel guilt or shame for certain actions even if no one else finds out? Could that point to a moral Lawgiver?”**
- **“You believe justice is important. What is the ultimate source of this conviction if not a higher, objective moral authority?”**
- **“When you see injustice or cruelty, you believe it’s genuinely wrong; not just inconvenient. Could there be an absolute moral standard beyond human opinion?”**

Encouraging Self-Reflection

Questions for the “Religious Man” of Romans 2, 3

Focus: The innate desire for God and love for others as evidence of divine revelation.

- “You are seeking a relationship with the divine. Have you considered why this longing is universal across cultures and time, and what that might suggest about a God who designed us to know Him?”
- “Your heart tells you there must be more than what you see around you. Where do you think this spiritual hunger comes from, if not from a Creator who wants to be known?”
- “You believe in loving your neighbor, but why should love be a fundamental good unless there is a God who Himself is love and made us in His image?”
- “When you pray or meditate, do you sense that you’re reaching out to someone real and personal? Could that Someone be the God who spoke through the prophets and ultimately through Jesus Christ?”

Encouraging Self-Reflection

Questions for the “Just Man” of Romans 4

Focus: Faith as the channel through which we are made right with God, illustrated by Abraham and fulfilled in Christ.

- “You trust that God keeps His promises, as Abraham did. Why would you believe that God is both faithful and true unless He has revealed Himself as unchanging, trustworthy, and righteous?”
- “Your faith points beyond your own goodness to something greater. If your moral efforts are never perfect, on what basis can you stand before a holy God, if not on the righteousness He provides by faith?”
- “Consider Abraham: he trusted God’s word before it was fulfilled. Has God’s faithfulness to Abraham and to countless believers since not shown that He is real and that we can be certain of His character?”
- “When you put your faith in Jesus Christ as the Just One, how does this confirm for you that God has revealed Himself in history, both through His written word and through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus?”